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Judas Iscariot

The chosen apostle who betrayed his Master for thirty pieces of silver.

Judas Iscariot was one of the Twelve. Jesus chose him, sent him out to preach and heal, and trusted him with the group's money. He saw the miracles and heard the teaching as closely as Peter and John did. Yet he became the man who handed Jesus over to his enemies. John says Judas was a thief who stole from the common purse. Luke and John say Satan entered him. For thirty pieces of silver he led an armed crowd to Gethsemane and marked Jesus with a kiss. When he saw Jesus condemned, he tried to return the money, and then he took his own life. His story is one of the most sobering in Scripture. It shows that being close to Jesus is not the same as belonging to him.

At a glance

Name	Judas, the Greek form of Judah, "praise"
Iscariot	Probably "man of Kerioth," a town in Judah; other meanings have been suggested (Joshua 15:25)
Family	Son of Simon Iscariot (John 6:71; 13:26)
Role	Treasurer of the Twelve; "had the bag" (John 12:6; 13:29)
Price	Thirty pieces of silver (Matthew 26:15)
Death	Hanged himself; the field bought with the money was called the field of blood (Matthew 27:5-8; Acts 1:18-19)
Successor	Matthias (Acts 1:26)

"But Jesus said unto him, Judas, betrayest thou the Son of man with a kiss?"

Luke 22:48, KJV

The life of Judas Iscariot

Dates are approximate (AD). The crucifixion is dated AD 30 or AD 33; this study uses c. AD 30. The last five entries fall within one week.

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| c. AD 28
<i>On a mountain</i> | ● Chosen as an apostle
Jesus names the Twelve after a night of prayer. In each Gospel list Judas Iscariot is named last and marked as the one who would betray him. <i>Luke 6:12-16; Mark 3:19</i> |
| c. AD 29
<i>Capernaum</i> | ● Singled out
When many disciples turn away, Jesus says, "Have not I chosen you twelve, and one of you is a devil?" John explains that he meant Judas. <i>John 6:66-71</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Bethany</i> | ● Objects to the ointment
Mary anoints Jesus with costly ointment. Judas asks why it was not sold and given to the poor. John says he cared not for the poor but was a thief. <i>John 12:1-8</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Jerusalem</i> | ● Strikes a deal
Judas goes to the chief priests and asks what they will give him to hand Jesus over. They agree on thirty pieces of silver, and he watches for his chance. <i>Matthew 26:14-16; Luke 22:3-6</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>The last supper</i> | ● Goes out into the night
Jesus says one of them will betray him and gives Judas the sop. Satan enters him, Jesus says, "That thou doest, do quickly," and Judas goes out. <i>John 13:21-30</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Gethsemane</i> | ● Betrays with a kiss
Judas arrives with a great multitude carrying swords and staves. He greets Jesus, "Hail, master," and kisses him, the agreed sign for the arrest. <i>Matthew 26:47-50</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Jerusalem</i> | ● Dies in despair
Seeing Jesus condemned, Judas brings back the silver and says he has betrayed innocent blood. The priests will not take it back. He throws it down in the temple and hangs himself. <i>Matthew 27:3-5</i> |

Key activities

Matthew says Judas hanged himself and the priests bought a potter's field with the money. Acts says Judas "purchased a field" with it and, "falling headlong," burst open. Many readers combine the two accounts; others see two independent reports. Both call the place the field of blood.

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- I Was chosen and sent.** He was among the Twelve whom Jesus sent to preach and heal. *Matthew 10:1-5*

 - 2 Kept the bag.** He held the group's money and stole from it. *John 12:6; 13:29*

 - 3 Complained about Mary's gift.** He called her ointment a waste that could have been sold for three hundred pence. *John 12:4-5*

 - 4 Let Satan in.** Scripture says the devil put betrayal into his heart and that Satan entered him. *Luke 22:3; John 13:2, 27*

 - 5 Sold his Master.** He asked the chief priests, "What will ye give me, and I will deliver him unto you?" *Matthew 26:15*

 - 6 Had his feet washed.** Jesus washed the disciples' feet, yet said, "Ye are not all clean," knowing who would betray him. *John 13:5, 10-11*

 - 7 Asked if it was he.** He asked, "Master, is it I?" and Jesus answered, "Thou hast said." *Matthew 26:25*

 - 8 Left the supper.** He took the sop and went out, "and it was night." *John 13:30*

 - 9 Kissed Jesus.** He used a sign of friendship to point out Jesus to the arresting crowd. Jesus called him "Friend." *Matthew 26:48-50*

 - 10 Regretted too late.** He said, "I have sinned in that I have betrayed the innocent blood," and brought back the silver. *Matthew 27:3-4*

 - 11 Took his own life.** He went out and hanged himself. *Matthew 27:5*

 - 12 Left an empty place.** Peter said Judas had gone "to his own place," and Matthias took his office among the apostles. *Acts 1:16-26*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Judas.

Old Testament

Psalm 41:9	The friend who ate bread, applied by Jesus (John 13:18)
Psalm 69:25; 109:8	Applied by Peter to Judas's empty office (Acts 1:20)
Zechariah 11:12–13	Thirty pieces cast to the potter; Matthew cites "Jeremy" (27:9)
Echo: Genesis 37:26–28	Judah sells his brother Joseph for silver
Echo: 2 Samuel 17:23	Ahithophel betrays David and hangs himself

New Testament

Matthew 26:24	Better for that man if he had not been born
John 17:12	None lost "but the son of perdition"
Acts 1:16–25	Peter recounts his end; a replacement is chosen
Tradition	His motives are debated; Scripture names greed and Satan's work

For discussion

- Observe:* What did Judas do after he saw that Jesus was condemned (Matthew 27:3–5)?
- Understand:* Peter and Judas both failed Jesus that night. Why did their stories end so differently?
- Apply:* Judas was stealing from the bag long before the betrayal. What hidden habit do you need to bring into the light?
- Apply:* The priests told Judas, "see thou to that." How could you point someone full of regret to Jesus this week?